



Above The chocolatiers of Bruges have taken chocolate-making from a conservative skill to a cutting-edge art, calling upon a long tradition

Left The enchanting city of Bruges is made up of perfectly preserved medieval and Gothic buildings towering above long, still waterways



Above Belgian chocolates are made from a vast array of natural ingredients, offering an exquisitely tempting choice at virtually every corner

Museum of Chocolate

Choco-Story (www.choco-story.be) is a museum that tells the story of chocolate from its origins to today. It has thousands of artifacts on display, from cocoa beans, chocolate-making utensils, machinery, and molds to hundreds of examples of ingenious packaging and much more. Visitors can stop off to watch demonstrations of chocolate-making techniques by expert chocolatiers. The collection is designed to appeal to all levels, including those who are interested in the finer details, such as the distinctive qualities of the various cocoa "vintages." The museum building itself is a historic 15th-century wine tavern.

The Best Places to Buy Belgian Chocolate

Chocolaterie Sukerbuyc expensive

Paule Helen Depreter founded Chocolaterie Sukerbuyc (the name means "sugar belly") in 1977, in the same premises it still occupies in Katelijnestraat, close to the museums. It is the oldest chocolate-making establishment in Bruges, and although it has remained a family business, it has come a long way in 35 years, increasing its production tenfold and establishing a reputation for superb handmade chocolates. You'll find a wide variety of pralines using dark, milk, and white chocolate based on 100 percent cocoa butter. Clients are encouraged to choose their own selection to fill the pretty boxes, and can see through the store into the workshop where the chocolates are made. The shop also produces fun pictures of Bruges by screen-printing dark chocolate onto a white chocolate background. Their café, *De Proeverie* ("the tasting place"), is opposite the shop, and is famed for both its exquisite patisserie and its hot chocolate drink, made by slowly melting a chocolate bar into hot milk.

Katelijnestraat 5, Bruges; open 8:30 AM–6:30 PM daily; www.sukerbuyc.be

Also in Bruges

Several of the major Belgian manufacturers of high-quality chocolates have high-street outlets in Bruges. These include **Neuhaus** (www.neuhaus.be) and **Leonidas** (www.leonidas.com). Although their products are made on an industrial scale, they maintain very high standards and the volume of sales means that their prices are relatively low, given their quality.

Also in Belgium

The major manufacturers all have numerous outlets in Brussels, but there are also smaller makers of exceptional quality. This includes the rising star **Pierre Marcolini** (www.marcolini.be) and the splendid traditional *pâtissier-chocolatier* **Wittamer** (www.wittamer.com), both on Place du Grand Sablon. Another noted producer is **Mary** (www.mary.be), supplier to the Belgian royal family, whose delightfully decorated Rococo-style shop is worth a visit in itself.

Around the World

Manufacturers producing top-quality chocolate are rare. **Valrhona** (www.valrhona.com/fr) is a French company founded in 1922 and based in the small town of Tain-l'Hermitage near Lyon; it prides itself on its careful sourcing of cocoa beans and its ability to extract their distinctive flavors. The US company **Knipschildt** (www.knipschildt.com), founded in 1999 by the Danish-born chef Fritz Knipschildt, has quickly built up a phenomenal reputation for the quality of its filled chocolates, truffles, and bars.